

Rationale structure changes evidence use

A matched prompt comparison on one time-bounded forecasting question

1 Forecasting task

Will China mass-produce humanoid robots by the end of 2025?

Resolves Yes only if a China-headquartered company produces >1,000 identical units before 31 Dec 2025.

2 Retrieved evidence

Criterion-aligned
The Robot Report, Sep. 2025

Several Chinese manufacturers began mass-production programs with targets above 1,000 units by the end of 2025.

Near-match
CNBC / Business Insider

Reports describe plans and future targets, but do not clearly establish the 1,000-unit threshold by the deadline.

3 Rationale intervention

Ask the model to foreground one attribute of the evidence

V0 Neutral
Brief rationale

No | 0.35
Treats evidence as plans

V4 Credibility
Assess source reliability

Yes | 0.68
Selects threshold-relevant report

V8 Temporal
Check event and deadline

Yes | 0.66
Checks the 2025 deadline

4 Forecast consequence

Scientific interpretation

The prompt does not add evidence. It changes which evidence the model treats as decisive; the effect depends on whether that evidence matches the resolution criterion.

Concrete example from the forecasting study (Metaculus 39523; GPT-OSS-120B). Across questions, the same intervention is evaluated with forecast accuracy, Brier score, and calibration.